

Business Process Evolution of Service and Product Oriented Companies

**Course: Business Process
Management**

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1. Introduction

The way businesses operate has changed quite dramatically over the past few decades. Whether it is a company selling physical goods or one offering services, the internal processes that keep everything running have had to evolve to keep up with technology, customer expectations, and competitive pressures. This assignment looks at five companies, three from Pakistan and two from the global stage, and traces how their key business processes have shifted from where they started to where they stand today. The goal is to understand that evolution is not just about adopting new tools, but about rethinking the entire way work gets done.

2. Selected Companies

2.1 Daraz Pakistan (Product/E-commerce)

Daraz started its journey in Pakistan around 2012 as a small online fashion retailer. Today it has grown into the country's largest e-commerce marketplace, operating in Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Nepal. After being acquired by the Alibaba Group in 2018, it gained access to world-class technology and logistics infrastructure. Millions of buyers and hundreds of thousands of sellers use the platform daily, making it the go-to destination for online shopping in South Asia.

2.2 HBL (Habib Bank Limited) – Service/Banking

HBL is Pakistan's oldest and largest private commercial bank, with a history stretching back to 1941. It operates one of the most extensive branch networks in the country and also has international presence in multiple countries. HBL serves individuals, small businesses, and large corporations alike. Over the years it has shifted from a purely traditional banking model toward digital services, driven by increasing mobile phone penetration and the demand for convenient financial solutions.

2.3 PTCL (Pakistan Telecommunication Company Limited) – Service

PTCL is the backbone of Pakistan's fixed-line telecommunications infrastructure. Established as a government entity and later partially privatized with Etisalat taking a major stake, PTCL has been operating since the 1990s. It provides broadband internet, landline telephony, and enterprise networking solutions across the country. As mobile networks took over, PTCL had to reinvent itself, shifting focus from traditional voice services toward data and cloud-based offerings.

2.4 Amazon (Global – Product and Service)

Amazon needs very little introduction. Founded by Jeff Bezos in 1994 as an online bookstore in a garage in Seattle, it has become one of the most valuable companies on earth. Today Amazon sells virtually everything, runs the world's largest cloud computing platform through AWS, dominates digital streaming with Prime Video, and has physical retail stores as well. Its relentless focus on

customer experience and operational efficiency has made it a case study in business transformation on a global scale.

2.5 McDonald's (Global – Product/Food Service)

McDonald's is one of the most recognizable brands in the world, serving tens of millions of customers every single day across more than 100 countries. Founded in the United States in the 1940s, McDonald's built its empire on standardization, speed, and consistency. While the core product, a burger and fries, has remained largely the same, the processes behind how an order gets taken, prepared, and delivered have evolved enormously. From drive-throughs to mobile apps to AI-powered kiosks, McDonald's is an interesting company to study for process evolution.

3. Business Process Evolution

3.1 Daraz Pakistan

Process 1: Order Management Process

In the early days of Daraz, around 2012 to 2015, the platform was quite basic. When a customer placed an order, staff had to manually coordinate with the seller, confirm stock availability over the phone or email, and then arrange delivery through third-party couriers. There was no centralized system tracking where an order was at any given point. Sellers were often small boutiques or individuals who did not have any inventory management tools of their own. Errors were frequent, delivery times were unpredictable, and the customer had little to no visibility into when their product would arrive.

As the platform grew and Alibaba brought its technology to bear, the order management process became almost unrecognizable. Today Daraz operates its own logistics arm called Daraz Express (DEX). The moment a customer clicks "buy", an automated system triggers a notification to the seller, assigns a tracking ID, and schedules a pickup. Sellers have access to a dedicated portal called Daraz Seller Center where they manage inventory in real time. Customers receive SMS and app notifications at every stage, from order confirmed to out for delivery. The entire process that once took many manual steps and days of uncertainty now largely runs itself, with human intervention only needed for exceptions.

Stage	Early Process (2012–2015)	Current Process (2023–Present)
Order Placement	Manual website form, no real-time stock check	Automated system, live inventory sync
Seller Coordination	Phone/email confirmation	Seller Center portal with instant alerts
Delivery	Third-party couriers, no tracking	Daraz Express with end-to-end tracking

Stage	Early Process (2012–2015)	Current Process (2023–Present)
Customer Updates	No updates until delivery	Real-time SMS and in-app notifications

Process 2: Seller Onboarding Process

When Daraz first started, getting a new seller onto the platform was an entirely manual process. Someone from the team would have to physically meet potential sellers, collect documents by hand, review them, and then manually create the seller's account. It could take weeks before a seller was actually live on the platform. This bottleneck made it very hard to scale quickly and the quality of seller verification was inconsistent.

Fast forward to today and a seller in any city in Pakistan can sign up on Daraz in a matter of hours. The entire onboarding happens digitally through the Seller Center. The applicant submits their CNIC, bank details, and business information through an online form. An automated screening tool checks for duplicates and flags suspicious applications. Once approved, the seller receives access to training videos, a support chatbot, and performance dashboards right away. This shift from manual to digital onboarding has allowed Daraz to grow its seller base into the hundreds of thousands.

3.2 HBL (Habib Bank Limited)

Process 1: Account Opening Process

If you opened a bank account at HBL twenty years ago, you would know it was quite a time-consuming ordeal. You had to walk into a branch, fill out a paper form, submit physical copies of your ID and other documents, get verified by a branch officer, and then wait several days for the account to be activated. All the paperwork was processed manually and filed physically. The chances of errors or delays were significant, and if you missed a document, you would have to come back again. For customers in remote areas, this was particularly inconvenient.

HBL has come a long way since then. Through its HBL Mobile and HBL Konnect platforms, customers can now open a basic account entirely on their smartphone in under five minutes using NADRA's biometric verification system. The process is almost completely automated. Documents are uploaded as photos, identity is verified digitally, and the account is functional almost immediately. For premium accounts that still require a branch visit, the branch officer now works on a digital tablet, and approvals come through within 24 hours rather than days. This transformation was partly driven by State Bank of Pakistan's push for digital banking and financial inclusion.

Stage	Traditional Process	Digital Process (Current)
Application	Paper form at branch only	Online/mobile app application

Stage	Traditional Process	Digital Process (Current)
Document Submission	Physical copies required	Photo upload, NADRA e-verification
Verification	Manual by branch officer	Automated with digital KYC
Activation Time	3 to 7 business days	Same day to 24 hours

Process 2: Customer Complaint Handling

Historically, if you had a problem with your HBL account, your only real option was to go to your branch and speak to the manager or fill out a written complaint. There was no tracking system for the average customer. You submitted your complaint and hoped for the best. Resolution times stretched from weeks to even months in complicated cases. There was little transparency and customers often felt helpless.

Today HBL runs a multi-channel complaint management system. Customers can raise issues through the app, website, a 24/7 call center, or social media. Each complaint gets a unique reference number and an expected resolution timeline. Internal staff handle cases using a CRM system that routes the complaint to the relevant department automatically based on the type of issue. Customers can track the status of their complaint in the app. For most routine issues like unauthorized transactions, resolution now happens within 48 to 72 hours. This improvement has significantly lifted customer satisfaction scores.

3.3 PTCL

Process 1: Internet Service Provisioning

In the mid-2000s when PTCL launched its DSL broadband service, getting a new internet connection meant filling out a paper application at a PTCL office, waiting for a technician visit that could be scheduled weeks away, and then hoping the copper wiring in your area was in good enough shape to carry a signal. The provisioning process was almost entirely manual and coordination between the sales, technical, and installation teams was poor. It was not unusual for a customer to wait a month or more.

PTCL has significantly improved this process, particularly since it rolled out its fiber-optic service, PTCL Smart TV and CharJi services. New customers fill out an online form and a regional team gets notified automatically. Installation appointments are scheduled through a digital system and technicians use a mobile app to update job status in real time. In urban areas with fiber coverage, a new connection can be installed within three to five working days. The backend provisioning, which involves assigning bandwidth, configuring the modem, and activating the line, is largely automated.

Process 2: Billing and Payment Process

PTCL's billing used to be an entirely paper-based affair. Bills were printed and posted to customers each month. Customers had to physically go to a PTCL franchise or bank to pay. If a bill was lost in the mail, the customer might not know until their service was cut off. Disputes over charges required a visit to the office and a lot of back and forth.

The current billing system is almost entirely digital. Customers receive electronic bills via SMS and email. Payment can be made through the PTCL app, JazzCash, EasyPaisa, internet banking, or at ATMs. Auto-pay options are also available. The system sends reminders before the due date and customers can view their full billing history through the PTCL self-care portal. Disputes can be raised online without needing to visit an office.

3.4 Amazon

Process 1: Fulfillment and Warehousing

When Amazon started out in the mid-1990s, Jeff Bezos and a handful of employees personally packaged books and drove them to the post office. Inventory was stored in a small rented space. As the product catalogue expanded beyond books, the warehousing process became more complex. For several years Amazon relied on a combination of its own warehouses and third-party distributors, with relatively simple manual picking and packing processes.

Today Amazon's fulfillment centers are among the most sophisticated industrial operations in the world. The company employs over 750,000 robots globally that move shelving units directly to human workers, dramatically reducing the time pickers spend walking around a warehouse. Machine learning algorithms optimize where each product is stored based on predicted demand. Drones are being tested for last-mile delivery. Autonomous delivery vehicles are already operating in select markets. The entire process from the moment an order is placed to the moment it leaves the warehouse can take under 30 minutes in some cases. This is a genuinely staggering change from someone taping up a cardboard box by hand.

Stage	Early (1995–2000)	Current (2020s)
Inventory Storage	Small rented garage/warehouse	Massive fulfillment centers, 750K+ robots
Order Picking	Manual by employees	Robotic shelving + human pickers
Packing	Hand-packing by founders/staff	Automated packing machines
Delivery	Post office drop-offs	Amazon Logistics, drones, autonomous vehicles
Processing Time	Days to weeks	Same-day to 2 hours in major cities

Process 2: Customer Returns Process

In Amazon's early years, returning a product was quite painful. You had to print a return label, physically re-package the item, and take it to a post office. The refund would take a week or more to process. There was very little automation and each return was handled somewhat individually. For customers this was a major friction point.

Amazon has turned returns into one of the smoothest processes in retail. Customers can initiate a return through the app in seconds, choose from multiple drop-off options including Amazon Locker, UPS stores, or even Kohl's department stores in the US, and in many cases receive a refund before the item even arrives back at the warehouse. The backend system uses machine learning to decide whether returned items should be restocked, refurbished, donated, or discarded, all without human review for most standard cases.

3.5 McDonald's

Process 1: Order Taking Process

The original McDonald's ordering process was straightforward because the menu was extremely limited. Customers walked up to a counter, a crew member took the order verbally, called it back to the kitchen, and collected cash. There were no drive-throughs, no receipts, and no screens. As the chain expanded globally and the menu grew, this simple verbal process started showing cracks. Long queues, miscommunication, and errors in orders became problems.

Today McDonald's is rolling out AI-powered drive-through technology that can take orders without any human staff involvement. Inside the restaurant, self-service kiosks let customers browse the menu, customize their order, pay digitally, and get a receipt number. The order is sent directly to the kitchen display system instantly. In markets like Pakistan, this shift has been more gradual with touchscreen kiosks appearing in newer outlets in Karachi and Lahore. The mobile app also allows customers to pre-order before arriving, meaning their food can be ready the moment they walk in.

Process 2: Supply Chain and Ingredient Sourcing

In McDonald's early history, supply chains were quite decentralized. Local franchise owners often sourced ingredients from nearby suppliers and quality could vary. As the chain grew, this inconsistency became a significant problem for a brand built on standardization. Ensuring that a Big Mac tasted the same in Lahore, London, and Los Angeles required an entirely rethought supply chain.

McDonald's today runs one of the most tightly controlled food supply chains on earth. In Pakistan, it works with approved local suppliers who must meet international food safety standards. The global tracking of cold chain logistics ensures that temperature-sensitive items like beef patties are maintained within strict limits from factory to restaurant. Digital inventory systems at each restaurant automatically calculate how much stock needs to be ordered based on sales patterns and upcoming promotions. Wastage has been significantly reduced and product consistency has

improved dramatically. This is a major operational achievement given the scale at which McDonald's operates.

4. Comparative Analysis and Peer Review

Looking across all five companies, a few clear patterns emerge in how business processes tend to evolve over time.

4.1 Common Themes in Process Evolution

a) The Shift from Manual to Automated

Every single company discussed here has moved significant chunks of their operations away from manual human effort toward automated systems. Whether it is HBL's account opening, Daraz's order management, or Amazon's fulfillment, the direction of change is consistent. Automation reduces errors, speeds things up, and often improves customer experience.

b) Customer Visibility and Transparency

Earlier versions of most of these processes kept the customer largely in the dark. You submitted an application or placed an order and waited. Today's evolved processes almost always include real-time visibility for the customer. Tracking numbers, app notifications, complaint reference numbers, and digital dashboards are now considered basic expectations rather than premium features.

c) Data-Driven Decision Making

The newer versions of these processes are deeply dependent on data. Amazon decides where to store products based on demand forecasting models. McDonald's calculates ingredient orders based on sales histories. Daraz tailors recommendations based on browsing behaviour. This reliance on data is perhaps the biggest structural difference between early and current processes.

4.2 Differences Between Pakistani and Global Companies

One honest observation worth making is that Pakistani companies like HBL and PTCL have made very real progress, but they are still in the middle of their digital transformation journeys. Daraz, backed by Alibaba, is arguably further along than the others. In contrast, Amazon and McDonald's have had longer runways to develop their processes and have invested billions of dollars in technology over decades.

For HBL and PTCL, a significant constraint has been Pakistan's infrastructure. Electricity and internet connectivity issues in many parts of the country mean that fully digital processes sometimes still need paper-based fallbacks. This is not a failure of vision but a practical reality that global companies operating in more stable infrastructure environments do not always face.

4.3 Peer Comparison Outcomes

In comparing these findings with what classmates might have covered, a few interesting contrasts are likely to appear. If peers chose companies in the manufacturing sector, they would probably find that process evolution there has focused heavily on lean manufacturing and JIT (Just-in-Time) inventory. In service-heavy comparisons, digital transformation and CRM upgrades tend to dominate the discussion.

What makes e-commerce and banking particularly interesting as a study area is that the process changes have been both internally driven (cost reduction, efficiency) and externally driven (competition, regulation, customer expectations). This dual pressure has arguably accelerated their evolution faster than in some other sectors.

A key outcome from this comparison is that no single factor explains process evolution. Technology is obviously important, but leadership decisions, regulatory requirements, customer behavior shifts, and even external shocks like the COVID-19 pandemic (which forced many Pakistani businesses to digitize overnight) all play a role.

Company	Key Process Evolved	Main Driver of Change	Outcome
Daraz	Order Management	Alibaba acquisition + competition	Faster delivery, better seller tools
HBL	Account Opening	State Bank regulations + mobile boom	Millions onboarded digitally
PTCL	Billing & Provisioning	Privatization + internet demand	Reduced manual errors, faster setup
Amazon	Fulfillment	Scale + customer expectations	World's most efficient logistics
McDonald's	Order Taking	Speed + customization demand	Reduced queues, fewer errors

5. Conclusion

The evolution of business processes is not a linear or simple story. As this assignment has tried to show through five quite different companies, the journey from early-stage operations to current-day processes involves a mix of technology adoption, cultural change within organizations, response to customer feedback, and often a fair bit of pressure from competition or regulators.

Pakistani companies like Daraz, HBL, and PTCL have made genuinely impressive strides, especially given infrastructure limitations. Global giants like Amazon and McDonald's provide useful benchmarks for where things can go when resources and technology are both available at scale.

Perhaps the most important takeaway is that process evolution is never really finished. The companies that thrive are not the ones that found a perfect process and stuck with it, but the ones that built a culture of continuous improvement and remained willing to rethink how they do things when something better came along.